

The Low-Cal High



Riding on the health wave, food and beverage companies are launching diet versions of calorific products like alcohol and chocolate. But are these products really as healthy as they claim to be?

■ By Malini Bhupta

Now you can eat ice creams, drink vodka and even polish off a couple of bars of chocolate without worrying about ugly love handles. Releasing consumers from the guilt of gastronomic indulgences is a clutch of food and beverage companies, which are burning midnight oil to deliver products that are low on fat and sugar.

Not surprisingly then, the diet foods market is one of the fastest growing segments of the food industry. It is driven by health-conscious consumers who want to indulge but not at the expense of their weight or wellness. Says R.S. Sodhi, chief general manager of Gujarat Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation, which manages the Amul brand: "In recent times consumer in-

terest in the relationship between diet and health has increased, pushing up the demand for low-calorie foods."

While the market for low-calorie foods is small in developing countries, India already ranks among the top 10 consumers of diet foods. The market size is expected to nearly double in the next five years. Total sales in this category are estimated to have grown by 3.8 per cent in value in 2006.

Diet products, with low fat and sugar content, have invaded virtually all the sectors of the food and drink market. From liquor companies to dairy processors, all major players have launched products that promise to liberate consumers from the ill-effects of fattening products. Chasing the diet el dorado along with the food companies are pharma majors, which are busy developing sugar substitutes and artificial sweeteners.

Increased awareness about illnesses like obesity and the risk of diabetes are driving people to opt for

sugar alternatives. Sugar-free chewing gums are doing well in India, though they still account for less than 6 per cent of the gum market. Among the favourites in this category is Orbit, the only sugar-free brand in the Wrigley India product portfolio, which was launched in the second half of 2004.

The current market size of the sweetener category, as per ORG retail audit, is close to Rs 70 crore, and is growing at about 15 per cent per annum. In recent times, the positioning of these products has also changed, with the target audience no longer being diabetics, but healthy people for whom sweeteners are preventive products. Says Sharvil Patel, deputy managing director of Zydus Cadila, which owns the brand Sugar Free, "Sugar Free is targeted at health and fitness-conscious people. It has



CALORIE KUM

DIET COKE: Among the earliest diet versions of the popular cola, the drink has only one calorie.

AMUL LITE BREAD SPREAD: Low on fat compared to butter and margarine, it also helps control diabetes.

SUGAR FREE NATURA: A zero-calorie alternative to sugar.

SUGAR FREE D'LITE: A low-calorie drink in powder and ready-to-drink form, fortified with electrolytes. It is available in five fruity flavours.

NESTLE KIT KAT LITE: Has 50 per cent less calories and fat than the regular Kit Kat chocolate.

WRIGLEY'S ORBIT: A sugarfree chewing gum, it claims to protect teeth from decay.



ICE ICE BABY: Amul has launched sugar-free ice cream

